Upwork niches for new freelancers

Small automation fixes beat crowded AI hype

Bottom line: live Upwork data from October 24, 2026 shows two different sets of niches. The busiest niches by raw posting volume are **virtual assistance (≈45 title-matched posts/day), Shopify (≈2 posts/hour), short-form video editing (10 posts in ~1.5 hours), SEO, logo design, WordPress, social media management and "AI agent" builds (20 posts in ~22 hours)**. The niches a no-badge, zero-job seller can realistically win are a narrower set, where proposal counts stay low and newcomers were visibly getting hired in September–October 2026. They are **AI UGC video ads** (only 2 of 20 posts had 50+ proposals, and at least 9 of the top 25 ranked sellers had no badge), **appointment/DM setting** (13 of 20 posts had fewer than 5 proposals), **short-form video editing**, **Shopify fixes**, and, for people who can actually code, **small "fix or extend my existing workflow" jobs in n8n/AI automation**. Those n8n posts are crowded (10 of 20 drew 50+ proposals), but no-badge sellers closed $50–$220 contracts there in October 2026, and one profile with $60 earned ranked #1 in search. Profit and winnability rarely line up. Admin, support and list-building work is easy to enter, but newcomers' effective pay converges at **about $3–7/hr**. Automation, app-rescue, Sheets/Apps Script and script work pay **$20–60/hr** from early contracts, but only to people with demonstrable proof. For **Harry** (a Nigerian CS graduate with real Claude Code, n8n, API and full-stack experience, a Roblox/Luau profile, 0 jobs and ~80 Connects), the evidence favors **dropping the Roblox positioning and making one coherent "AI automation & integration developer" profile**. That profile should cover three niches: **n8n/API workflow fixes (with voice/WhatsApp-agent add-ons)**, **rescuing vibe-coded apps (Lovable/Supabase/Claude Code)**, and **Google Sheets/Apps Script and Python script automation** as the low-competition, review-building side door. It should be backed by Loom-walkthrough portfolio items and proposals sent within the first hour of posting.

How to read this report. Everything labeled **Observed** comes from a read-only pull through the Upwork API (MCP connector) on **October 24, 2026, about 06:00–11:10 UTC**: job searches by title keyword sorted by recency, freelancer searches, and full profile pulls with contract dates, earnings and review text. Job and profile text is self-written by third parties. Claims inside it ("$15M generated", "Anthropic Certified", "500+ projects") are **unverified**. Market-wide figures come from Upwork filings and vendor reports. Those were read through **search-engine snippets, not full pages**, because direct fetches failed. Vendor figures (GigRadar, Vibeworker, SnipeWork, JobsPipe) come from companies selling Upwork tools. Statements labeled **Inference** are analysis, not observation. Harry-specific Roblox figures come from this project's local job pull and account audit (October 5–20, 2026).

One day of live data has four blind spots

The snapshot is a single day, so it says nothing about seasonality or week-to-week trend. **Job matching is by title only**. A job about n8n without "n8n" in its title was not counted, so every volume figure is a lower bound, and some niches are undercounted more than others because their work is spread across many keywords (Sheets/Apps Script, scripts, AI evaluation). Each niche was sampled at 10–20 of its newest posts, and volume was estimated from the time those posts span. "≥20 in 22 hours" means the sample cap was hit, not that only 20 exist. **The freelancer search's job-count filter is unreliable.**

Searching "1–10 jobs" returned people with 30–130 contracts: Waqar Hussain S. showed "2 completed jobs" in search but has 96 jobs and 77 contracts on his profile (profile), and Tasleem B. showed under 10 but has 83 jobs (profile). So "newcomer" claims in this report rest on **contract dates in full profiles**, not on search filters. The API exposes Top Rated, Top Rated Plus and Expert-Vetted, but **never Rising Talent**, so "no badge" here means none of those three. Proposal texts, profile views, invites and hire outcomes per job are not visible, so the report can show *who won and when*, but not how many proposals each win took. Review text was returned for some profiles (AI, web and admin pulls) but rarely for creative profiles, where the API mostly returned active contracts without feedback.

One recurring artifact matters for budget reading: **$5 and $10 fixed budgets appear in every niche**, often from clients with hundreds of posts. These look like placeholder budgets rather than real prices (Inference).

Volume sits in design, video and Shopify while growth sits in AI

Upwork's own growth story is about AI. In Q2 2026 AI-related gross services volume grew **more than 22%** to about a $330M run-rate, and the **AI Strategy & Consulting** subcategory grew **more than 50%** (Upwork 8-K Q2 2026). Management also said AI automation is accelerating "mainly in very low-complexity work" (Equibles transcript) and that clients increasingly want AI translation "humanized" (Investing.com transcript). Its In-Demand Skills 2026 report found AI-referencing skills up **109%**, against 23% for other in-demand skills, while full-stack development, general VA, data analytics and graphic design remained the most consistently demanded by volume (Quartz; CNBC).

Volume tells a different story. Vendor Vibeworker analysed **252,697 skill-tagged posts from June 1 to July 31, 2026**. The leaders were **Graphic Design (32,887 posts), Video Editing (24,017) and Social Media Marketing (22,693)**. Shopify had 8,878 posts and Python 6,144, and **all AI-tagged skills combined were only about 3% of postings** (Vibeworker). SnipeWork's weekly index put Design & Creative first every week in September 2026 (SnipeWork W37). The market is also shrinking at the top end. GigRadar counted **448,118 jobs in Q2 2026, down 14.2% quarter over quarter**, with expert-level jobs falling 19.1% against 10.9% for entry-level, and fixed jobs over $5K falling 18.8% (GigRadar Q2 2026). Only **about 8–11% of posts are labeled entry level** (SnipeWork W38; W40). The typical budget is small: in July 2026 the median fixed budget was **$80**, about **42% of fixed posts were under $50**, and only 17.4% were $500 or more (Vibeworker July 2026).

Competition data points the same way the live snapshot does. Across 133,872 mostly agency proposals, GigRadar found a **7.45% mean reply rate**. Web development replied at **5.80%** and mobile at 5.60%, while lead gen/telemarketing, sales copywriting, game design, PR/brand strategy, infosec and product design replied at **10.8–14.6%** (GigRadar category map). In Q2 2026 a first reply cost about **$14 in Connects for video editing versus $50 for web development**, and writing suffered the largest drop in engagement (reply rate down to **5.2%**) (GigRadar Q2 2026). **Inference:** for a newcomer, the "fastest-growing" list (AI) and the "biggest" list (design, video, Shopify, VA) are both less useful than a third list: niches where *small, well-scoped posts* still draw few proposals. The live data below identifies that third list.

The 26-niche scoreboard: where demand, competition and newcomer wins meet

The table ranks every niche sampled on October 24 by how realistically a **no-badge, zero-job seller can win and then grow pay**. It is not ranked by raw volume. The demand and competition columns are **Observed** (title-matched sample of the newest 10–20 posts). The rank, the barrier rating and the "path" column are **Inference**. "Newcomer evidence" names the newest no-badge or recently started winner found, with the date of their latest observed contract.

#	Niche	Demand (observed velocity)	Competition (proposal tiers in sample)	Entry barrier	Starting pay seen	Path to higher pay	Newcomer evidence (observed)
1	**AI UGC video ads**	20 posts / ~48 h	Only 2/20 at 50+; 11/20 at 10–20	Low–medium (portfolio of AI samples)	$10–20 per test ad; $5–15/hr	$87 hourly in 2 weeks; $2,880 hourly; $2,200/mo + bonus retainers	Boluwatife D., no badge, $100+ earned, 9 jobs, new contract Oct 22
2	**Appointment / DM setting**	≈28/day	**13/20 under 5**; none 20+	Low (scripts, US hours, voice/English)	≈$5/hr effective	≈$10/hr; $20–40/hr expert posts	Charity F. (NG), no badge, 5 contracts Aug 29–Oct 20
3	**n8n / Make / Zapier automation (fix & extend)**	≥20 / ~68 h	10/20 at 50+; 9/20 at 20–50	Medium (real workflow skill + demos)	$50–220 fixed fixes	$35/hr at 10 jobs; $56/hr US; $5.7K hourly contracts	Abdul R., no badge, $220 ended Oct 21; Masud S., $150 started Oct 15
4	**Short-form video editing**	~10 posts / 1.5 h (highest)	4/20 under 5; 1/20 at 50+	Low–medium	$10–30 fixed per edit	$20–50/hr effective on hourly clients	Dua D., new account, ~20 contracts in 7 weeks, latest Oct 20
5	**Shopify fixes / setup / tracking**	~20 posts / 10 h (≈90+/48 h)	**7/20 under 10**; 1/20 at 50+	Medium	$50–230 fixed; $5/hr profiles	$880 builds; $40/hr bundled offer	Varnika C., no badge, 13 fixed jobs all Oct 2026
6	**Virtual / executive assistant**	≈45/day (highest admin)	6/20 under 5; none 50+; 9/20 entry level	Very low	≈$5–7/hr effective	EA hourly roles; podcast-booking specialty	Queen O. (NG), no badge, EA contract started Oct 23

#	Niche	Demand (observed velocity)	Competition (proposal tiers in sample)	Entry barrier	Starting pay seen	Path to higher pay	Newcomer evidence (observed)
7	**Google Sheets / Apps Script automation**	~6 / 48 h (undercounted)	7/10 at 20–50; 1/10 under 5	Medium (needs proof)	$15–175	**$55/hr from first contract**; $850 fixed	Rayan S., no badge, $850 job started Oct 14
8	**Small scripts / bug fixes (Python, JS)**	"bug fix" ~8 / 48 h; "Python script" ~2 / 48 h	Mostly 15–50; 1/10 under 10	Medium (real coding)	$30–175 fixed	$60/hr; $410–1,000 jobs	Christopher H., no badge, ~10 contracts in ~3 weeks (Oct)
9	**Vibe-coded app rescue (Lovable, Bolt, Supabase)**	"Lovable" 10 / 6.4 days; "vibe coded" 10 / 3 weeks	5/10 at 50+	High (React/Supabase, security)	$20–544 first jobs; $5–10 "quick fix" posts	$2,230 hourly; $2,500 builds	Akram S., no badge, $400 audit started Sep 16
10	**Social media management**	20 / ~16 h	**6/20 under 5**; 8/20 at 10–15	Low	$3–12/hr	Audits → long hourly VA/SMM roles	Miracle A. (NG), no badge, ~34 contracts since ~Jun, latest Oct 20
11	**AI evaluation (SME / native language)**	3 / 72 h by title (undercounted)	Mixed; several 10–15, one under 5	Gated (domain or language)	$5.50–60 micro-gigs	$20–150/hr SME posts; $6.1K hourly annotation	Olutaiwo A., Top Rated ~3 months after start; Allen G. M., hourly started Oct 9
12	**Meta ads fixes & pixel/CAPI setup**	~10 posts / 5 h ("Meta ads")	Mostly 10–50	Medium–high (platform knowledge)	$25–40 fixes	$60/hr; monthly management	Ayoub K., new Jul 2026, 34 contracts, latest Oct 16 (credentials-led)
13	**AI agents & voice agents**	≥20 / ~22 h (highest AI)	**13/20 at 50+**	High; badge-saturated search	$15 fixes; $250 builds	$3,058–3,920 hourly	No no-badge voice newcomer found; Jarrar U. Top Rated at 5 jobs
14	**Webflow / Framer**	~15–17 / 48 h	Webflow 5/10 at 50+	High (design portfolio)	$110–1,525	$35/hr; rehires	Illia M., no badge, 2 jobs, $1,000 Sept

#	Niche	Demand (observed velocity)	Competition (proposal tiers in sample)	Entry barrier	Starting pay seen	Path to higher pay	Newcomer evidence (observed)
15	**YouTube thumbnails**	20 / ~44 h	5/20 under 5; 7/20 at 10–15	Low	$5–50	Upsell to channel management	Fathima R. ($15 → hourly management; Top Rated); search 0/25 no-badge
16	**Customer support (chat/email)**	≈13–14/day	11/20 at 20+	Low–medium (helpdesk tools)	≈$3–4/hr effective	SaaS customer success at $15–25/hr	Cecilia N. (NG), no badge, long contract from Aug 19
17	**GoHighLevel**	~20 / 20 h (≈48/48 h)	**0/20 under 10**; 15/20 at 20+	Medium	$5–15/hr; $25 fixes	$20–25/hr CRM implementations	Daniel B., no badge, new contract Oct 19
18	**Data entry / web research**	≈14–15/day	10/20 at 20+; 5/20 at 50+	Very low	$2.50–10/hr; $10–50 fixed	$700–1,100 research engagements	Mirah M. (NG), now Top Rated, new contract Sep 27
19	**WordPress / Elementor**	~20 / 14.5 h	0/20 under 5; 15/20 at 20+	Low–medium	$10–45 micro-fixes	~$20/hr hourly builds	MD N., ~10 jobs since Sep 22; Waseem I.
20	**Lead gen list building**	≈27/day (≈30% are ads jobs)	5/20 under 5; 4/20 at 20+	Low	$50 per 100 contacts ≈ $5/hr	Market research, SDR roles	Olayinka A. (NG), $50 Lagos audit Sep 25–Oct 1
21	**SEO**	10 / ~4 h	Mostly 20–50	Medium	$3–25/hr	Long contracts at ≈$5/hr	Akhil K., $15 local-SEO job Oct 2 (older account)
22	**Logo / brand design**	20 / ~14 h	**14/20 at 20–50**; 1/20 under 5	Low skill bar, high polish bar	$25–200	$350–750 brand kits	Rotna R. (new account, Top Rated Plus via 120 contracts); search 0/25 no-badge
23	**Pitch deck / presentation**	10 / ~67 h (lowest creative)	Mostly 20–50+	Medium	$10–55 reformatting	$250 decks	Agung M., Top Rated at ~$1K via $10–50 tasks

#	Niche	Demand (observed velocity)	Competition (proposal tiers in sample)	Entry barrier	Starting pay seen	Path to higher pay	Newcomer evidence (observed)
24	**Generic data annotation**	1 / 72 h by title	4/10 at 50+	Low	$3–12/hr	Thin	Profiles at $3–10/hr
25	**Bookkeeping (QBO/Xero)**	~13 genuine/day	0/20 entry level; 8/20 at 20+	High (certs, country experience)	$5–9/hr effective	$18–25/hr nonprofit/CPA roles	Joy O. (NG), via ProAdvisor cert and $10 paid test
26	**LinkedIn ghostwriting**	≈0.6/day	6/10 at 20–50; 0 entry	High (own audience)	≈$5–6/hr effective	$400/founder/month	Bukky M. (NG), $4/hr, Top Rated

For comparison, Harry's local pull of **40 Roblox jobs (October 5–20, 2026)** works out to roughly 2.7 posts/day, with **30% under 5 proposals** and 12 of 20 fixed budgets under $200 (local project data). By that measure Roblox would sit around ranks 5–9: less crowded per post than n8n or AI agents, but with much lower volume and a lower budget ceiling.

Inference on what the table means. Three groups emerge. The **easy-entry, low-pay group** (VA, customer support, data entry, list building, SEO, social media) lets almost anyone land a first contract, but effective pay converges at **$3–7/hr** in every admin profile pulled. The **proof-gated, well-paid group** (n8n automation, Sheets/Apps Script, scripts, app rescue, Webflow, Meta ads) starts at $20–60/hr for people who can show working demos. The **current sweet spot**, where volume, low competition and visible newcomer wins all coincide, is AI UGC video, appointment setting and short-form video. That is a talent and taste business, not a coding one.

AI niches reward fix-it jobs, not "build me an agent"

n8n and no-code automation: crowded posts, but newcomers close $50–$220 fixes

Observed: 20 jobs with "n8n" in the title were posted between October 21 11:59 and October 24 08:09 UTC, 13 of them in the last 48 hours. The proposal tiers were heavy: **10 at 50+, 9 at 20–50, 1 at 10–15, none under 10**, and no post was labeled entry level. Budgets ranged from placeholder $5–10 to **$100, $200, $300, $380, $750, $1,400 and $2,000 fixed**, with hourly bands of $10–60. Typical posts were a $380 "n8n AI Automation Specialist – Customer Support Email Workflow" from a client with $48K spent (job), a $1,400 "n8n Developer for Vapi Integration" that logs voice-agent calls to Google Sheets and sends a daily email (job), and a $100 "n8n Developer Needed for Simple API Automation" (webhook → validate JSON → external API) (job). Language-gated work also appeared: a Polish-speaking voicebot job at $2,000 (job) and an n8n audit requiring German or French (job). Blog-sourced rate estimates put n8n at **$40–100/hr** for experienced freelancers, and describe self-hosting as requiring Docker/VPS skills (AdSniper).

The freelancer side is where this niche gets interesting. In the "n8n AI automation" search, 20 of 25 results had Top Rated or Top Rated Plus, but **the #1 result was Simon K., a Danish freelancer with no badge, $60+ earned and one job** (profile). His only contract was a $60 Danish-native AI voice-agent evaluation (October 3–5, 2026; review: "Good freelancer, committed to the quality."). His profile has a niche-exact title ("AI Automation Specialist | n8n Workflow Automation | AI Agents"), a promise of a

personalized Loom video for every invite, and five portfolio items each titled "WATCH THIS: ... Full Loom Breakdown!" (RAG chatbot, support-email workflow, invoice extraction, HubSpot lead intake with error handling). **Masud S.** (Pakistan, $35/hr, no badge, JSS 90, 10 jobs) shows the fix-and-extend ladder: "Fix & Improve n8n AI WhatsApp Workflow" ($60, October 9), "Add Lead Tracking and Follow-Up Automation to an Existing n8n WhatsApp Bot" ($50, October 12), a $217 n8n + Vapi + Botpress build, and an active $150 WhatsApp AI assistant started October 15. His latest review (October 12) says he "knows n8n inside and out... fixed the workflow issues" (profile). He writes outcome lines ("Took 40 emails a day down to 3"), lists 16 portfolio items with their stacks, and offers consultations from $10. **Abdul R.** (Pakistan, $20/hr, no badge, JSS 100, 5 jobs) won "AI Automation Expert Needed for n8n, OpenAI & API Integration" ($100, September 16; "quickly fixed our AI agent workflow, API integration, and CRM automation issues"), then 5 hourly hours at $100, then a $220 job ending October 21 ("Will work with Abdul again! Recommended!") (profile). At the top end, US-based **Clayton B.** went from first visible contract in February 2026 to Top Rated with **$5,775 and $5,603 hourly contracts** by October. His most recent review, from a "I am looking for a Claude magician" job, says he "clearly knows his stuff in the Claude world" (profile).

Inference: this is the strongest coding-skill niche for a newcomer, but only through one door: small, well-defined repairs or extensions of a client's *existing* workflow, delivered in 1–3 days. Simon's ranking suggests that a tool-exact title, video walkthrough portfolio items and recent activity count heavily in search. That is one data point, not a proven rule. Because almost every post is at 20+ proposals within hours, speed of application is the only way a 0-review proposal gets read.

AI agents and voice agents: the most posts, and the most badges

Observed: "AI agent" titles produced **20 posts in about 22 hours**, the highest AI volume measured, but **13 of 20 had 50+ proposals**, 10 were expert level and only one was entry level. Heavy spenders post here: a French client with $323K spent ($50–100/hr), a Ukrainian client with $246K and 546 jobs, a US client with $131K. Examples include a $1,200 "AI Career Coach Agent" from a German client with $56.9K spent (job), an "AI voice agent expert" to make a Retell prompt sound human at $10–100/hr (job), and one newcomer-sized post, "Voice AI Developer Needed for Retell AI & Vapi (Appointment Booking Agents)", **$250 fixed with fewer than 5 proposals** when sampled (job). On the talent side, the "AI voice agent chatbot" search returned **25 of 25 badged** profiles, and "Retell AI Vapi voice agent" 22 of 25. **Syed Muhammad Jarrar U.** reached Top Rated with only **5 jobs in about 7 months** after a $650 first contract (March–May 2026), a $70.83 paid architecture consultation and a $3,920 hourly AI-assistant contract. His overview leads with verifiable credentials (Georgia Tech MS CS, prior lead AI engineer role) (profile). **Muhammad Umair A.** won a **$15** "AI Engineer for Voice Agent Fixes" job (August 28–30; "did an excellent job resolving issues with our AI Voice Agents") alongside a $3,058 Retell hourly contract, with Loom walkthroughs of clinic voice agents in his portfolio (profile).

Inference: a new profile will not surface in this search. Low proposal tiers ("Fewer than 5", "5–10") appeared only on posts minutes old. Treat voice and WhatsApp agents as an **add-on to an n8n profile** (Masud's pattern), not a standalone niche. Many posts span both ("n8n Developer for Vapi Integration").

Vibe-coded app rescue: thin title volume, clear pain, trust-led positioning

Observed: "Lovable" titles produced only **10 posts over about 6.4 days**, and "vibe coded" 10 over about three weeks. Most were expert level, and 5 of the 10 Lovable posts had 50+ proposals. Budgets are bimodal. On one side are $5–10 "quick fix" posts, such as "Quick fix for a small Lovable app: login and signup errors" (Lovable + Supabase, entry level, 20–50 proposals) (job) and "Quick Fix on Our AI-Built App (Lovable/Bubble)" from a client with 1,218 posts (job). On the other are builds like a **$2,500** job to

publish a Lovable e-learning platform as Android/iOS apps with in-app purchases (job), "App finishing and move from lovable.dev" (job) and "Vibe coded site, need a developer to solidify the code" from a US client with $49.9K spent (job). A related "bug fix" search surfaced "Senior Developer to Stabilize, Clean Up, and Fix an AI-Built Business App (React/Supabase)" at $25–60/hr (job). Off-platform, 404 Media (via Mezha) reports freelancers and firms making money fixing AI-written code (Mezha). No Upwork-specific job counts exist.

Akram S. (Uganda, $18/hr, no badge, JSS 100, $6K+) is the clearest newcomer path in any AI niche. He started with a **$20** Lovable/Bolt/Replit job (June 2025), moved to a $544 Lovable platform build ("built the best platform I could have ever dreamed of"), then a **$2,230.83 hourly** Lovable contract (March–August 2026, "scope… became much larger… incredibly flexible"), and since September 16, 2026 an active **$400 "Read-Only Recoverability Assessment"**. His overview opens with "Most of my clients now arrive with 50–70% of an app already built using Claude Code, Replit, Lovable or Bolt", stresses RLS/security hardening and moving off Lovable Cloud, and promises "I start read-only, change nothing without your approval" (profile). **Dhruvit K.** (India, $12/hr) retitled himself "Fix Lovable, Bolt & Vibe-Coded Apps | Next.js + Supabase Developer" without any visible vibe-code contracts, on the strength of a $500 AML-chatbot accuracy job ending August 26 (profile). Five of the top 25 in "Lovable Supabase vibe coding" search had no badge.

Inference: many rescue jobs say "React/Supabase developer" without naming Lovable, so true demand is larger than the title counts. The winning pitch is **safety and ownership**: read-only audit first, tested backups, security fixes. "I can vibe-code too" does not sell.

AI UGC video ads: the most newcomer-friendly niche observed

Observed: 20 "AI UGC" posts in about 48 hours, with **only 2 at 50+ proposals**, 6 at 10–15 and 5 at 15–20. Clients include a UK buyer with **$1,003,987 spent** and 806 posts ("AI UGC video creator", $5–15/hr, ongoing per video) (job), a skincare brand offering **$2,200/month plus uncapped bonuses** (job), and a DTC brand that "hit $100K days on Meta" (job). At least **9 of the top 25** in "AI UGC video ads" search had no badge, several on 2026-era accounts. **Boluwatife D.** (Poland, $12.25/hr, no badge, $100+ earned, 9 jobs) won $10, $10, $15 and $10 test ads between September 28 and October 12, then an $87.10 hourly ad, and started a new contract on **October 22, 2026**. Review (October 9): "Exceptional AI video creator!… voiceovers, movement, and captions looked completely natural." His profile carries 90 heavily keyword-stuffed portfolio items (profile). **Christian Mark M.** (Philippines, $12/hr, no badge), whose profile was created around March 2026, turned AI UGC samples into a **$2,880 hourly** contract (since August 12) and a $680 fixed job (since October 2) (profile). Vendor data agrees: video/animation proposals replied at **10.76%** against a 6.95% baseline (GigRadar video).

Inference: sample videos are the whole pitch, and supply hasn't caught up. The low tier ($5–15/hr) is poor pay. The money is in the "creative strategist" tier: hooks, scripts and Meta performance.

Data annotation and AI evaluation: a review-starter, not a career

Observed: generic "data annotation" titles were thin (**1 post in 72 hours**, 10 over 6.5 days) and cheap ($3–12/hr, often 50+ proposals). Examples: a $10–12/hr RegTech annotation role from a client with $5.72M spent (job) and a $50 bounding-box job with 10–15 proposals (job). "AI evaluation" posts paid **$20–150/hr** but are gated by domain or language: one US client with $513K spent posted four healthcare-SME eval jobs, such as "Internal Medicine SME – AI Evaluation" at $20–55/hr (job). Also posted: "Senior Software Engineer – AI Coding Agent Evaluation & Task Development" at $20–30/hr with 5 hires (50+ proposals) (jo

b) and an India voice-AI evaluation at $20–50/hr with fewer than 5 proposals (job). **Olutaiwo A.** (Canada/Quebec) reached **Top Rated about three months** after starting in July 2026. He began with location- and language-gated micro-gigs ($34.72 product test; $5.50 Canadian-French recording, 5★ "follow the instructions well!"), then won a **$6,132.50 hourly** image-captioning contract (423.5 h, ≈$14.5/hr). He is currently on a **Yoruba audio transcription** contract started October 19 (profile). **Allen Gabriel M.** (Philippines, no badge) climbed from $10 labeling to Hiligaynon and Tagalog linguist work and an "AI Model Evaluation Expert LLM Testing" hourly contract started October 9 (profile).

Inference: scarcity (a less common native language, a country gate, a credential) is the moat. These gigs produce fast first reviews (Simon, Olutaiwo and Allen all used them), but the niche itself is too thin and cheap to build a positioning on.

Web and dev niches split into cheap volume and proof-first premium

Shopify has the most volume and the softest competition of the dev niches. Observed: 20 Shopify-titled posts in about 10 hours on October 24, with **7 of 20 under 10 proposals** and only one at 50+. Budgets ran from $50 to $2,500 fixed, and hourly bands from $5–6 to $12–27. Narrow technical posts drew the fewest bids: "Meta Pixel & CAPI Setup for Shopify" from a UAE client with $55.6K spent had **fewer than 5** (job), and "Shopify Store Setup from Amazon" ($50) had 5–10 (job). Many "Shopify" titles are really support or ads roles at $5–8/hr (job). Two newcomer models coexist. **Asad U.** (Pakistan, $5/hr, no badge) won three contracts in September–October, including $230 for 23 hours (profile). **Varnika C.** (US, $40/hr, no badge) won **13 fixed jobs, all in October 2026**, including an $880 store build, with a bundled title ("Shopify Store Setup + Product Videos & AI Video Ads for Ecommerce"), a "live in 3 days max" promise and "I send a clear scope and price before anything starts" (profile).

Google Sheets/Apps Script and small scripts have low volume and high rates. Observed: about 6 relevant "Google Sheets" posts per 48 hours (half of them data-entry noise) and roughly 8 "bug fix" posts per 48 hours across stacks. Real automation posts paid $20–50/hr, such as "Google Sheets Automation Expert | Inventory, Pricing & Quoting" (job) and "Port Legacy Windows Tool Logic to Python" ($150, 10–15 proposals) (job). **Rayan S.** (US, $55/hr, no badge, 0 reviews yet) has been paid **$55/hr from his very first contract** ($559 mail merge, September 16–October 2) and won an **$850** fixed job for 28 auto-certificate Google Forms on October 14. His proof is "built and published 11 add-ons to the Google Workspace Marketplace — all through Google's OAuth security review", plus a paragraph on Apps Script quotas and 6-minute limits (profile). **Raphael L.** (Nigeria, $17/hr, no badge) laddered from a $15 Looker Studio dashboard to "Automations & AI" at $454.50 ("fully custom AI dashboard... connecting all tools in 1 place") and a $280 job whose client says it saved "£2,000... per month" (profile). **Christopher H.** (US, $60/hr, no badge) won about **10 contracts in three weeks of October**, from $100 email-deliverability fixes to a $410 "Node.js Developer for AI SMS Receptionist" and a $1,000 site restructure. His stated tactic: "usually a working demo or a concrete plan right in my proposal" (profile). **Ana Luisa P.** (Brazil, $25/hr, self-taught) followed a $30 PowerPoint job with a $275 n8n YouTube automation ("very high integrity... I am already hiring her again") and a $175 "Python Developer – Script Setup (GitHub, 3x APIs, & Slack Webhook)" ("working, bulletproof, 100% functional code") (profile). Default "Python script" search was the most open of any dev niche, with **about 7 of 25 unbadged**.

WordPress, GoHighLevel and Webflow/Framer are busy but hard. Observed: WordPress drew ~20 posts in 14.5 hours, but **none under 5 proposals** and 15 of 20 at 20+. Veterans with 138–309 jobs dominate search. GoHighLevel drew ~20 in 20 hours with **0 of 20 under 10 proposals**, and big spenders still post $6–7/hr (job). Entry exists through narrow repeatable fixes. **MD N.** built ~10 WordPress micro-

contracts ($10–45) from September 22 (profile). **Krystal H.** sells GHL A2P 10DLC registration ("helped to get my a2p approved after several attempts myself") (profile). **Daniel B.** reframes GHL as RevOps ("Most companies don't have a CRM problem. They have a revenue problem...") and has run $650–1,137 hourly contracts since June (profile). Webflow/Framer pays better ($110–1,525 first contracts) but search was 23–25 of 25 badged. **Illia M.** won $1,525 and $1,000 jobs from two contracts using a QA angle and "30 days of free bug fixes" (profile). A 1–2 hour Webflow scroll-animation fix had fewer than 5 proposals (job).

Inference: in dev niches the gap is not skill but **verifiable proof**. Public add-ons, live demos and named client sites let Rayan, Christopher and Illia skip the $5/hr ladder that Asad and MD N. climbed.

Creative, marketing and admin niches are easy to enter and slow to pay

Video, thumbnails and social media have real openings at low prices. Observed: "video editor" produced 10 posts in about 1.5 hours, the fastest velocity of any term. Across 20 short-form posts, 4 had fewer than 5 proposals and only 1 had 50+. Examples include "Short-Form Video Creator & Editor for Tech Product Reels (8–10 videos/day)" at $8–12/hr with fewer than 5 proposals (job) and a CapCut editor at $6–15 per video from a client with $8.4K spent (job). **Dua D.** (Pakistan, no badge), whose account appears to date from about August 2026, logged **about 20 contracts in 7 weeks** from September 6. These were mostly $10–30 test edits, alongside hourly jobs that worked out to $20–50/hr effective. Her small portfolio relies on before/after side-by-side reels (profile). Social media management produced 20 posts in about 16 hours, with **6 of 20 under 5 proposals** (job). **Miracle A.** (Lagos, no badge) built about 34 contracts since roughly June at $12.27/hr (profile). Thumbnails produced 20 posts in about 44 hours with 5 under 5 proposals, but search was 0 of 25 no-badge, and budgets run as low as **$5,000 for 1,000 thumbnails** (job). Logo (14 of 20 at 20–50 proposals), pitch deck and SEO were crowded and dominated by Top Rated sellers. Their entry points are micro-tasks: vector cleanup of AI-made logos (job), PowerPoint reformatting, and Google Business Profile fixes (job). **Ayoub K.** (Berlin, $60/hr) is the clearest credentials-led newcomer. He listed former Meta-support work, opened his account around June–July 2026, and won 34 contracts by October fixing "ads not spending" and account restrictions, converting into monthly management (profile).

Appointment setting is the standout admin niche. VA has the most posts. Observed: "appointment setter" produced ≈28 posts/day, **13 of 20 under 5 proposals and none above 15**. Examples include a $10–20/hr Apollo cold-calling role from a client with $3,900 spent (job) and a $20–40/hr home-building setter role from a client with $17.5K spent (job). Commission-only posts are common (job). **Charity F.** (Akwa-Ibom, Nigeria, no badge) won **five contracts between August 29 and October 20**. Her portfolio is demo-heavy: a call-volume dashboard, a cold-call script and a mock gatekeeper call. Review: "attentive to the task and consistently kind and respectful" (profile). **Precious Onyinyechi N.** (Imo, Nigeria) earns ≈$10/hr as an Instagram DM setter across seven concurrent contracts (profile). VA produced ≈45 posts/day, 9 of 20 entry level and 6 of 20 under 5 proposals, at $3–15/hr (search). **Queen O.** (Lagos, no badge) went from a $5 app-testing gig to EA roles, one started October 23. Her first long contract paid ≈$6/hr (profile). Customer support (11 of 20 posts at 20+ proposals), data entry (5 of 20 at 50+), list building (22 of 25 searched sellers Top Rated, $50 per 100 contacts), bookkeeping (no entry-level posts) and LinkedIn ghostwriting (≈0.6 posts/day) all look worse. Every Nigerian newcomer pulled in those niches earned **≈$3–7/hr effective** at first (Cecilia N.; Sandra E.; Joy O.).

Inference: in these niches the entry barrier is low because pay is low. The upside comes from specialization (podcast booking, SaaS customer success, DM setting, Meta troubleshooting), not from the starting niche.

What gets newer freelancers hired, and the padding not to copy

Across roughly 40 profiles pulled, **Observed** traits of newer winners repeat in every niche. The first is a **tool- or outcome-exact title** that mirrors client search words ("n8n", "Lovable", "Seedance", "A2P 10DLC", "Hiligaynon"). The second is an **opening line about the client's pain or a number**, for example Masud's "40 emails a day down to 3", Akram's "50–70% of an app already built", Precious A.'s unread-email story (profile), and Charity F.'s call dashboards. Third, **proof assets beat claims**: Loom walkthroughs (Simon, Muhammad Umair), live apps (Akram), Marketplace add-ons (Rayan), before/after clips (Dua) and redacted real spreadsheets (Olayinka A., profile). Fourth, a **low-friction entry product**: $10–50 consultations, audits, "free 30-min store review", paid trials. Fifth, **first contracts that were tiny ($5–60) and closed in 1–3 days**, followed by **repeat hires** (Davyd Z.: "I rehired Davyd because he is exceptionally good and works super fast" (profile); Ana Luisa; Cecilia: "I had to rehire Cecilia"). Intro videos appeared on most of the admin winners and about 5 of 12 dev profiles. Badges came fast: Olutaiwo was Top Rated about three months after starting, Jarrar after 5 jobs, Agung with about $1K earned (profile). **Inference:** "no badge" is a short phase, and the first five clean reviews matter far more than the badge.

A mass-hire gig, "100 Needed for Reading/Response Project" ($30 fixed, recurring as Alpha/Branch/Omega batches), gave **four separate Nigerian newcomers** an early 5★ review (Queen O., Olayinka A., Sandra E., Charity F.). Simon K.'s only review came from a $60 off-niche language eval. These are legitimate and useful as first reviews, but they say nothing about the main skill (Inference).

Patterns not to copy. Several winning profiles also show padding that a careful client or Upwork's trust team can spot. All of the following is **Observed** on the profile; that it is risky is **Inference**, not verified against Upwork enforcement. **Esther A.** lists ~90 employment records naming Palantir, Verizon and Gusto, has 181 portfolio items, and shows five $10 contracts with polished 5★ comments ("She found exactly where my cash was leaking...") on a $200+ profile (profile). **Adeleke Q.** shows several $10 Shopify jobs in October with long, near-identical 5★ reviews, about 100 employment entries with generic agency names, and "design concepts" named after Gymshark and Fashion Nova (profile). **MD N.**'s overview claims "Top Rated... 500+ Projects... Upwork Rising Talent" against 10 jobs and $200 earned. **Asad U.** self-claims "Top 5% Shopify Expert", and one mockup in his portfolio carries Huel branding. **Tasleem B.**'s overview claims a 100% JSS while the profile shows 85. **Sadia A.** has 121 near-identical keyword-stuffed portfolio items and hashtag spam (profile). **Miracle A.** lists about 45 "education" entries that are mostly free YouTube certificates. **Marvellous I.** is titled "LinkedIn Ghostwriter", but all ten visible contracts are romance novels (profile). On the client side, two Nigerian clients posted $20 Framer jobs with 24–42 posts and only $286–463 spent, and a GHL client had 446 jobs and $5.5K spent (job). Both look like micro-task or review-building patterns. The project's earlier Roblox study found the same thing: a profile with staged-looking $5 "full game" reviews had earned only $10+. **Inference:** keyword density appears to help ranking (Boluwatife, Miracle A., Sadia A.), but fabricated employers, false badge claims, brand-name mockups and review farms damage trust, and Sadia's JSS of 86 suggests clients notice.

Harry should choose automation over Roblox and sell fixes, not builds

Since **May 28, 2026, Upwork has no Specialized Profiles**: one title, one overview, one skill set (Upwork Help). Uma, Upwork's AI recruiter, now shortlists for clients on every plan by matching job text to that single profile (Upwork investor release). Harry therefore cannot be both a Roblox scripter and an automation developer without weakening both matches.

Recommendation (Inference): make the main positioning **"AI Automation & Integration Developer — n8n, Claude Code & APIs | Fix, Extend & Finish AI-Built Workflows and Apps."** This one coherent profile covers three of the table's niches. **n8n/API workflow fixes** (#3) is the core, with voice-agent and WhatsApp add-ons borrowed from #13. **Vibe-coded app rescue** (#9) draws on his full-stack and Claude Code skills. **Google Sheets/Apps Script and Python script automation** (#7–8) serves as the lower-competition side door. Remove Roblox from the title, overview and skills. Keep the Roblox demo for DevForum and Discord, where Roblox buyers already gather.

The case for switching rests on five points. **Volume:** n8n alone produced ≥20 title-matched posts in ~68 hours and "AI agent" ≥20 in ~22 hours, against roughly 2.7 Roblox posts a day. **Ceiling:** automation posts run $100–$2,000 fixed and up to $50–100/hr, and newcomer peers reach $35–56/hr within months, against Roblox's 12 of 20 fixed budgets under $200. **Proof of newcomer wins dated this month:** Abdul R. ($220, ended October 21), Masud S. (started October 15), Simon K. (ranked #1 with $60). **His real experience**, which a CS degree and Claude Code work make verifiable through demos. **Upwork already reads him this way:** on October 20 its recommender returned **10 of 10 AI-automation jobs** for his Roblox profile (local audit). The earlier plan treated that as a bug to fight; it is better used as a tailwind. **The steelman for Roblox** is real: 30% of Roblox posts had fewer than 5 proposals, against none under 10 for n8n. A Roblox proposal is therefore more likely to be read. But that advantage sits in a small, price-sensitive pool, and speed of application can recover much of the n8n gap (Inference). Fallback trigger: if roughly 30 well-targeted automation proposals (≈350 Connects) produce no interview, revisit the choice. That threshold rests on vendor benchmarks of a 2–8% newcomer win rate in the first 30 proposals (GigUp).

Niches that are a poor fit despite ranking high: **AI UGC video, appointment setting and short-form video** rank #1, #2 and #4 for newcomers generally, but they would waste Harry's coding edge and pay $5–15/hr at entry. **AI evaluation** is worth one or two bids as a review starter if a post needs a Nigerian language (Yoruba, Igbo, Hausa) or a software engineer (job). It is not a positioning.

A 30-day entry plan for three fitting niches

Profile (days 1–3). Title as above. Opening line, outcome-first, for example: "Your n8n workflow or AI-built app is 80% done and breaking in production — I fix, extend and harden it, starting read-only." Skills: n8n, Make, Zapier, API Integration, Claude/Anthropic API, OpenAI API, Supabase, React/Next.js, Google Apps Script, Python, Vapi/Retell, WhatsApp Business API. List a public rate of **about $20/hr**, in line with the no-badge peers at $15–35 (Simon $15, Abdul $20, Ana Luisa $25, Masud $35). Raise it to **$30** after 3–5 five-star reviews and **$35–45** after about 10. Add a 60-second intro video and a **$10–30 consultation**, the pattern Masud, Dhruvit and Boluwatife use. Trim employment to honest entries, and make every claim checkable. Connects cost **$0.15** each (Upwork) and a typical proposal costs about **11–12** in vendor samples (useoutbid), so his ~80 Connects buy about **6–8 proposals**. Spend them only on the filter below, and top up with $15 bundles of 100 as needed. Budget about $45–55 for a month of 1–2 proposals a day. Do not boost.

Proof (days 2–10). Build five Loom-walkthrough portfolio items, each mirroring a live post type (Simon's "WATCH THIS" format):

1. A support-inbox triage workflow in n8n that uses Claude to classify and draft replies, with retries and an error branch. This mirrors the $380 job.
2. A Vapi or Retell call → n8n → Google Sheets log plus a daily summary email. This mirrors the $1,400 job.

3. A webhook → JSON validation → external API workflow with logging. This mirrors the $100 job.
4. A before/after rescue of a deliberately broken Lovable + Supabase app: auth fix, row-level security hardening and a written read-only audit. This follows Akram's pattern.
5. An Apps Script tool, such as Forms-to-certificate or a mail merge with quota handling, published publicly if possible (Rayan's proof model).

Put the stack, what he personally built, and the outcome in each description.

Niche A: n8n/API fix-and-extend (primary). Bid only on posts **under about 60 minutes old**, payment-verified, scoped as one workflow or one fix, at $50–400 fixed or hourly. Low proposal tiers appeared only on minutes-old posts. Open with the client's exact failure and the fix ("Your webhook returns 200 but the API call silently fails; I'd add JSON schema validation and an error branch that alerts you"), link the matching Loom, quote a fixed price at or slightly below budget with a 1–3 day delivery, and offer a one-minute Loom answer. Vendor data associates that offer with +3.7 points of reply rate (GigRadar). Include voice-agent and WhatsApp posts ("make my Retell agent sound human", "log calls to Sheets"). These are the $15–250 fixes Muhammad Umair and Masud won.

Niche B: vibe-coded app rescue (secondary, higher ticket). Target "Lovable/Bolt/Replit/Supabase/AI-built app" posts plus generic React/Supabase stabilization posts. Lead with safety: read-only audit first, client keeps ownership, nothing deployed without approval. Treat $5–10 "quick fix" budgets as placeholders. Quote a real fixed price ($40–80 for an auth or login fix) or offer a paid audit (Akram's $400 recoverability assessment is the template).

Niche C: Sheets/Apps Script and Python scripts (side door). Lower volume, but default search here was the most open to no-badge profiles, and buyers pay for demos. Bid on API-to-Sheets syncs, scraper repairs and script ports ($100–200). Christopher's tactic of putting a working demo or concrete plan inside the proposal fits Harry's Claude Code speed.

First-month targets (Inference). Send 30–40 proposals and aim for **1–2 hires**, consistent with the 2–8% newcomer benchmark. Deliver early, send a short progress clip, and ask once for the contract to be closed with feedback. Turn each fix into a next step ("workflow fixed — want error alerts and a weekly report added?"), because repeat hires drove most of the newcomer ladders observed. Keep every pre-contract message on Upwork and never run files a prospect sends (Upwork Help). Days 31–90: shift toward $200–500 fixed and $25–35/hr hourly work, add a paid "automation audit" offer, and re-check search position for "n8n", "AI automation" and "Lovable" every two weeks.

Conclusion

Asking which niche has "the most jobs" mostly leads to the wrong place for a newcomer. The highest-volume niches (VA, logo, SEO, WordPress, "AI agent" builds) are either crowded with Top Rated sellers or pay $3–7/hr at entry. The niches where zero-review sellers were winning *this month* share a structure: a client with an existing asset (a store, a workflow, an AI-built app, an ad account) that is broken or unfinished, a fix that takes 1–3 days, and proof that can be shown in a 60-second video. That structure, not the AI label, is what makes n8n fixes, app rescue, Shopify tracking and UGC test ads winnable.

For Harry, the switch from Roblox to automation is less a change of skill than a move to a larger pool where his CS background is credible and Upwork's matching already points him. The biggest unknown is how fast a proposal must arrive on a crowded automation post to be read at all. The snapshot only shows

that low proposal tiers exist for minutes, not hours. That makes his early weeks an experiment in speed and proof, measured by a proposal log, rather than a bet on how many Connects he spends.